Cognitive simplicity

Designing slides and resources that support attention

Use cognitive simplicity when slides or resources compete with the explanation. Reduce unnecessary searching, reading and distraction so students can attend to the content that matters.

How to do it well

1 Identify the essential information. Decide what students need to see, hear or read at the current point.

2 Remove competing material. Delete decorative elements, irrelevant detail and duplicated language that adds no explanatory value.

3 Reduce searching. Group related content, label clearly and keep the important feature easy to locate.

4 Sequence the reveal. Introduce information in coherent chunks and separate reading, listening and copying when they would compete.

5 Test the resource. Check readability from the back of the room and whether students can locate the reference needed during practice.

What this sounds like

“Read these two sentences silently first. I will then explain the distinction. Watch the highlighted phrase as we connect it to the diagram.”

Classroom example. A teacher removes an unrelated image, moves labels beside the diagram and reveals one part at a time. Students read a short definition in silence before the teacher explains its connection to the visual. The revised resource reduces competing demands while retaining the reference information pupils need during practice.

Top tips that make the technique work

Remove decorative competition. An irrelevant picture or animated effect can attract attention away from the learning feature.

Place related information together. Keep a label beside its diagram feature and a condition close to the step it affects.

Reveal deliberately. A completed diagram or crowded page may demand more processing than the current explanation requires.

Stop talking over new reading. Give students time to inspect substantial unfamiliar text before explaining it.

Preserve useful reference material. Simplicity does not mean removing the model or vocabulary students need to practise successfully.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Use layout and sequence to direct attention.	Decorative images, clutter and redundant text.
Keep text and visuals purposeful.	Removing essential information merely to make a slide look sparse.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation. Some links support part of this guide rather than the whole technique.

DistillED — Explaining With Precision